

Name: Canete, Khent C.

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Offender Behavioral Analysis: Integrating Learning, Development, and Personality Theories

PART A: Learning and Behavior (Social Learning & CBT)

Mark's behavior can be explained using Social Learning Theory by Albert Bandura. This theory states that people learn by observing and imitating others. Mark was exposed to peers involved in crime and later joined a gang where theft and violence were normal. He copied these behaviors because they were rewarded with acceptance, respect, and possible financial gain. The gang environment reinforced his actions, making crime seem acceptable and necessary.

Mark also shows a cognitive distortion called **justification**. He believes stealing is acceptable because "everyone in the group does it" and that it is necessary to survive. This thinking reduces his sense of responsibility and makes his actions seem reasonable to him.

PART B: Psychosocial Development

According to Erik Erikson, Mark is in the **Identity vs. Role Confusion** stage. At this stage, adolescents try to find their identity and sense of belonging.

Mark is experiencing **role confusion**. Due to a lack of parental guidance, he struggled to develop a positive identity and instead found belonging in a gang. This led him to adopt behaviors that gave him acceptance, even if they were harmful.

PART C: Cognitive Development

Based on Jean Piaget, Mark is in the **Formal Operational Stage**, meaning he can think logically and understand consequences.

However, he shows poor judgment in applying this thinking. He focuses on short-term rewards like acceptance and survival rather than long-term consequences. This results in risky and illegal decisions.

PART D: Moral Development

Using Lawrence Kohlberg, Mark is in the **Pre-conventional Level (Stage 2)**. At this level, decisions are based on personal benefit.

Mark justifies stealing because it helps him survive and because others do it. His lack of remorse shows that he does not consider laws or the impact of his actions on others.

PART E: Personality and Crime

Two personality traits that contribute to Mark's behavior are:

1. **Easily Influenced** – Mark is vulnerable to peer pressure, which allowed the gang to shape his behavior.
2. **Low Empathy** – His lack of remorse suggests he does not fully understand or care about the harm he causes others.

These traits make him more likely to engage in criminal behavior.

PART F: Intervention and Recommendation (HOTS)

1. Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)
2. CBT can help Mark identify and correct his cognitive distortions, such as justifying theft and following group behavior blindly. Through structured sessions, he can learn to challenge irrational thoughts, develop accountability, and improve decision-making skills. This intervention addresses the root of his thinking patterns, helping prevent repeated criminal behavior.
3. Family Intervention and Social Support Programs
4. Strengthening family involvement and supervision is crucial. Programs that improve parent-child communication and provide consistent guidance can help Mark rebuild a healthy support system. Additionally, community-based programs (e.g., mentoring or youth rehabilitation groups) can offer positive peer influence, replacing the gang's role in providing belonging and identity.

These interventions work together by reshaping both Mark's internal thought processes and external environment, significantly reducing the likelihood of reoffending.